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Wakuénai Ceremonial Exchange in the Venezuelan Northwest Amazon

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This study aims to contribute to the comparative ethnology of the Northwest Amazon region by providing detailed descriptions and analyses of musical performances, dances, and other activities making up *pudáli*, a tradition of ceremonial exchange practiced among the Northern Arawakan Wakuénai of the Guainía and Isana rivers. At the time of my fieldwork in 1980–1981, pudáli ceremonial exchanges were in a state of flux, reflecting major changes in social organization and subsistence economics happening throughout the Venezuelan Amazon Territory. In those villages where the musical dances of pudáli were still being performed, the context had changed from the exchange of food-gifts between affines to small social gatherings for the purposes of dancing and drinking together. Nevertheless, my inquiries in various Wakuénai communities along the lower Guainía River indicated that ceremonial exchanges of surplus foods had been commonly practiced until the recent past. Most of the information contained in this study results from my fieldwork in the village of a highly ranked Dzáwinai ("Jaguar-People") sib whose adult members had participated in pudáli ceremonial exchanges as young adults.

AUTHOR'S NOTE: Financial support for my fieldwork with the Wakuénai in 1980–1981 was furnished by the Social Science Research Council and the Fulbright-Hays Program. I am also grateful to the Instituto Venezolano de Investigaciones Científicas (IVIC) and the Instituto Interamericano de Etnomusicología y Folklore (INIDEF) for logistical support within Venezuela. Special thanks also to Anthony Seeger, Nelly Arvelo-Jiménez, Isabel Aretz, José Jorge de Carvalho, Robin Wright, Janet Chernela, Norman Whitten, Terence Turner, and Dan Rose, among others, for their intellectual stimulation and comments on drafts of this article.

In the early stages of my fieldwork with the Dzáwinai and their Waríperídakéna ("Pleiades-Grandchildren") in-laws, I recorded several hours of instrumental music and songs, transcribed some of it, and learned to perform many of the flute duets. I began to understand the basic sequence of musical performances, dances, songs, and other activities of pudáli through extensive dialogues with men and women in the village. This process developed slowly at first, due in part to the fact that I had to learn a new dialect, called Curricarro, of Wáku, which was quite different from the Curripaco dialect I had studied earlier in an Ádzanéni ("Armadillo-Children") village downstream. When my verbal skills had improved and local people understood that my purposes were to document and understand their tradition of pudáli in as much detail as possible, the process of searching the villagers' collective memory took on its own momentum. What had started as a number of tenuous, isolated dialogues soon turned into a multivocal, collective interest in teaching the resident anthropologist about pudáli ceremonial exchanges.

The very fact that the Wakuénai continued to perform the dance-music of pudáli even though the indigenous practice of food-gifts between affinal sibs had largely ceased to exist alerted me to the possibility that pudáli might embody cultural processes that transcended its social and economic functions. Exploring this possibility, I found that the ceremonial process of breaking down the social boundary between kin and affine (or hosts and guests) in pudáli indeed formed part of a more general social process of disintegrating the cultural separateness of human and nonhuman animal species and of male and female humans. Pudáli ceremonial exchanges provided social occasions for evaluating, commenting upon, and redefining the meanings of humanness, human masculinity, and human femininity in the publicly critical situation of coping with potentially dangerous "others," or affines. When pudáli is understood as a process of socially constructing the precultural, presexual space-time of shared mythic Beginnings through playing music, dancing, singing, and drinking together, its continuation in the context of rapid social changes can be interpreted as an indigenous strategy for becoming human in increasingly dehumanizing historical conditions.

The Regional Context of Pudáli

Social Organization in the Northwest Amazon Region

The Arawakan phratries of the Isana-Guainía drainage area refer to themselves as Wakuénai, or "People of Our Language" (Hill 1983, 1984), and they have had historically deep relationships of warfare, trade, and intermarriage with their Eastern Tukanoan neighbors to the south and west (Chernela 1983; Reichel-Dolmatoff 1985; Wright 1981). Like the Cubeo

phratries of the Cuduyarí River (Goldman 1979), those of the Wakuénai are, or were, localized in riverine territories and can act together as a defensive unit to repel outsiders (Hill 1983; Wright 1981). The Cubeo self-name Pamíwa also translates as "People of the Language" (Jackson 1983:178), and there is clear evidence of a historical connection between the Wakuénai and the Cubeo: "One of the Cubeo phratries was, in fact, once Arawakan" (Goldman 1979:26). In-depth studies of Wakuénai language and social organization are just beginning to appear (Hill 1983; Journet 1981; Wright 1981; Wright and Hill 1986), still lagging behind the study of Eastern Tukanoan societies (Chernela 1983; Goldman 1979; C. Hugh-Jones 1979; S. Hugh-Jones 1979; Jackson 1983; Reichel-Dolmatoff 1971, 1976). Comparison of Northern Arawakan and Eastern Tukanoan social organization and of the intermediate Cubeo system promises to reveal cultural relations of great complexity (Hill 1985*a*; Reichel-Dolmatoff 1985).

Like the neighboring Eastern Tukanoan peoples of the Vaupés basin, the Wakuénai phratries of the Isana-Guainía drainage area view language as a basic organizing principle of their social relations. However, the Wakuénai do not practice language group exogamy and institutionalized multilingualism. Whereas the Eastern Tukanoan peoples rationalize their social relations by attributing maximal social importance to differences within a family of closely related languages (Jackson 1983; Sorenson 1967), the Wakuénai place social value on the mutual intelligibility of five dialects, which are named after the different pronunciations of the words for "yes" or "no." Although there are no clear, one-to-one correspondences between dialect-groups and phratries, each dialect is strongly associated with a general region within the Isana-Guainía drainage area and with a specific phratry.

Each phratry consists of four or five named patrisibs, ranked in a serial order according to the order of emergence of mythical ancestors from beneath the waterfalls at Hípana, a village on the Aiarí River in Brazil (Hill 1983; Nimuendajú 1950; Wright 1981). In everyday social contexts, the names of the highest-ranked sibs within each of the phratries serve as terms of social reference and conveniently mark the social boundary between kin (*nukítsiñápe*) and marriageable others (*apána naíki*, "other people"), or affines. Relations among phratries are not ranked but characterized by competition and shifting alliances among parties of equal status.

Hierarchy within phratries is based on mythical order of emergence from the ground at Hípana, a place which is regarded as the sacred center, or "navel," of the world by all Wakuénai phratries. Other Arawak-speaking peoples of the Venezuelan Amazon, including the Baniwa, Guarequena, and Piapoco, also consider Hípana to be their place of mythical origins. The degree to which the Wakuénai myth of emergence is standardized and refers to a single, common place of shared origins is in sharp contrast with

Eastern Tukanoan origin myths, which outline a much more mobile process of ancestral anaconda-spirits who swam up the rivers like giant canoes, dropping off the various sib ancestor spirits.

In comparison with the Eastern Tukanoan narratives, Wakuénai origin myths establish a relatively fixed, determinate order of sib ranking from oldest to youngest brother (or first-born to last-born). However, the Wakuénai are more flexible than the Eastern Tukanoans in the way they apply the elder/younger brother distinction in actual social life. At the level of a group of brothers within a local sib, the Wakuénai frequently, but not always,[1] invert the rule of rank at the collective level by setting up an expectation that the younger brothers will achieve higher status than the older brothers within the sib through becoming village headmen and/or powerful ritual specialists. This expectation has a mythical precedent, since it was two younger brothers of the trickster-creator (Iñápirríkuli) who took on the powerful roles of chant-owner (*málikai limínali*) and first initiate (*wálit'áki*, or "newly-fasted one") (Hill 1985*a*). Thus, for the Wakuénai, siblingship is capable of ordering social relations in quite different ways within various domains: from first-born to last-born in the ranking of sibs within each phratry and from last-born to first-born in the expected level of achieved status among brothers within each sib.

Among Eastern Tukanoan peoples, the principle of rank according to relative age among male siblings is ideally expected to operate in the same way at the level of brothers within each sib and at the collective level of sibs within each phratry. In other words, accession to leadership roles within the local community replicates the pattern of rank among sibs through the belief that the headman of each longhouse should ideally be the oldest of a group of brothers. However, in actual social practice, the oldest brother does not always accede to headmanship due to denial mechanisms, flexibility, and ambiguity that enter into the application of ranking principles to specific individuals and groups. The succession of headmanship, for example, ". . . can involve a great deal of argument," and a headman must ". . . initially and continually prove himself worthy of the job" (Jackson 1983:104).

Marriage in the Northwest Amazon

As mentioned above, the Wakuénai do not practice language group exogamy like the Eastern Tukanoan peoples. Instead, the entire language

[1]Wright's work (1981) on the Hohódeni phratry of the Aiarí River in Brazil demonstrated that the oldest brother of a sibling group is expected to accede to positions of power and leadership. The Hohódeni have intermarried extensively with Uanano and Cubeo of the Vaupés basin, and it is thus possible that their use of the seniority principle among siblings has become "Tukanoized."

group is internally divided into several phratries. These exogamous groupings are named after the highest-ranked (or oldest brother) sib and were formerly localized in distinct riverine territories along the Guainía, Cuyarí, Isana, and Aiarí rivers in Venezuela, Colombia, and Brazil (see Figure 1). Wakuénai phratries strongly resemble the Cubeo phratries of the Cuduyarí River (Goldman 1979), with the exception that they do not practice hierarchical zoning, or the placement of higher-ranked sibs in downstream locations and lower-ranked sibs in upstream areas.

In spite of historical dislocations during the Rubber Boom and more recent migrations of sibs, or fragments of sibs, into new areas, Wakuénai phratries remain strongly associated with specific riverine territories.[2] The continuous occupation of riverine territories by patrilineal sibs and phratries was supported by a patrilocal rule of post-marital residence after a brief, one-to-two-year period of uxorilocal residence during bride service. In recent years, residence patterns have begun to change, and in some villages, uxorilocal residence is statistically more common than patrilocality (Hill and Moran 1983).

Bride service was considered[3] the only legitimate means of establishing affinal alliances between sibs of different phratries. Young men were expected to live in their wives' villages and work for their prospective fathers-in-law. Specifically, they were required to cut new manioc gardens for their fathers-in-law and provide his household with fish and game meat (Hill 1983; Matos Arvelo 1912). Personal accounts of bride service depict it as a critical transition in young men's lives, when they underwent intense scrutiny and obeyed strict rules of respect for their future affines. Young men who were judged to be lazy or incompetent in their fulfillment of bride service duties could be sent away without their brides. This veto power of fathers-in-law was greatly feared, and young men who failed the test of bride service suffered a sort of social death. Predictably, the father-in-law figure plays an enormously prominent role as the leader of the animal-affine enemies of the trickster-creator (Iñápirríkuli) in the cycle of narratives about the space-time of mythic Beginnings at Hípana (Hill 1983).

The importance which the Wakuénai attribute to bride service as a process of establishing legitimate, balanced social relations among affinal sibs is quite different from marriage practices among the Eastern Tukanoan peoples, who view sister exchange as the ideal form of marriage (Jackson 1983:128). Although sister exchange is only realized in a small percentage

[2]The sense of belonging to a specific place is given expression in sacred narratives and musical performances. In curing rituals, for example, shamans (*malírri*) must travel to the houses of the dead souls in the netherworld (*íyarudáti*) to retrieve their patients' souls. Each of these houses is named and assigned a specific place within the home territory of the phratry.

[3]Past tense is used in this description of bride service among the Wakuénai, since the practice was strenuously suppressed by the New Tribes missionaries.

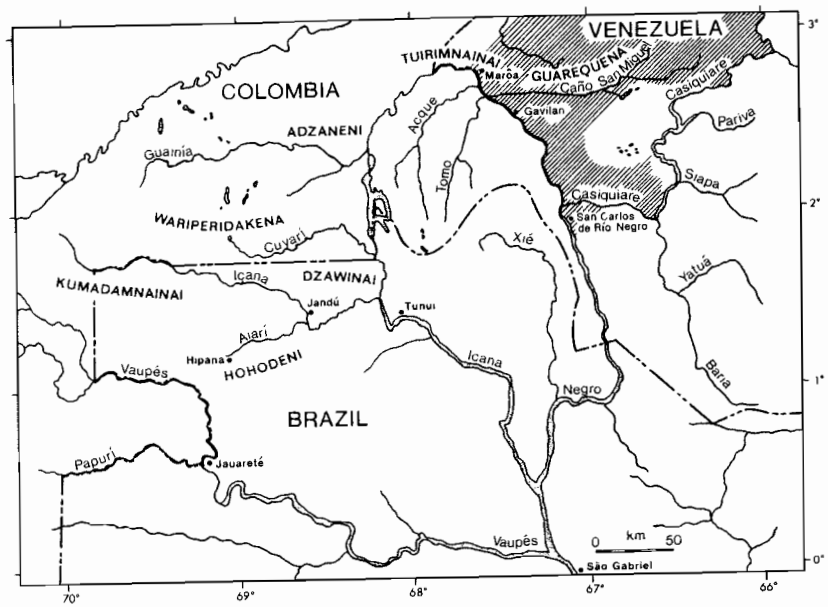


Figure 1. Northwest Amazon region centered around Wakuénai lands in the Isana-Guainía drainage area of Venezuela, Brazil, and Colombia.

of actual marriages, the ideal of sister exchange is broadened to include the exchange of classificatory and ceremonial sisters. In addition, marriages between first bilateral cross-cousins is considered an acceptable alternative to sister exchange (Jackson 1983:128). The general principle underlying all these forms of marriage is that ". . . only a woman given compensates for a woman received" (Jackson 1983:126). Although some marriages between more distantly related sibs do take place, the more common strategy is to form relatively stable alliances with closely related sibs.

The Wakuénai also practice bilateral cross-cousin marriage, but their marriage system is less restricted, or direct, than that of the Eastern Tukanoan peoples. Among the Wakuénai, sister exchange is not at all in evidence, either as cultural ideal or as social practice. Instead, both the stated ideal and actual practice are oriented to a strategy of marriage with distant cross-cousins or with other groups who are not the traditional affines. The result of this strategy is quite different from the Eastern Tukanoan marriage pattern of pairs of closely related affinal sibs. For the Wakuénai, the marriage strategy results in the spreading of affinal ties as widely as possible among sibs of equivalent rank in other phratries. Bride service, or the principle that male productive labor and social deference to wives' kin groups compensates the latter for the eventual loss of female labor and fertility, was the social means for negotiating and mediating between distant, potentially hostile, affinal sibs.

Ceremonial Exchange in the Northwest Amazon

The differences between marriage practices of the Wakuénai and those of the Eastern Tukanoan peoples account for many of the contrasts between traditions of ceremonial exchange among affinal sibs in the two subregions of the Northwest Amazon. Wakuénai ceremonial exchanges, called pudáli, were coordinate with the practice of bride service and consisted of a two-part cycle of ceremonial food-gifts. In opening, male-owned ceremonies, a local group visited a host group of actual or potential affines (wife-givers) and formally offered them a gift of smoked fish or game meat. The initiation of a pudáli cycle was most frequently carried out in the beginning of the long wet season, a time when the various species of *Leporinus* fish migrate and spawn in huge schools in areas of newly flooded forest. Large surpluses of the *Leporinus* fish are captured by closing off the mouths of streams with traps before the fish return to the main channel of the river. Although the ideal timing of pudáli was after the fish spawning runs early in the long wet season, a man could decide to initiate pudáli ceremonial exchanges during any season of the year when he happened to capture a large surplus of fish or game meat. In return, the recipients of the smoked meat were obligated to sponsor a closing, female-owned pudáli several weeks later in which they prepared and offered a large quantity of processed manioc pulp.

The principal objects given away for redistribution in pudáli, smoked meat and processed manioc pulp, represented the quintessential products of male and female labor, respectively. The exchange of these male and female products was a symbolic enactment in miniature of the practice of bride service, or a loaning of male labor in exchange for the eventual loss of female labor. Just as bride service was a period during which young men contributed their labor to their wives' kin groups before later returning to their natal villages with their brides, pudáli cycles enacted a loaning of the products of male labor to affinal sibs before a later repayment in the form of the products of female labor.

Ceremonial exchanges of smoked fish and game meat between affinal sibs have also been widely reported among the Eastern Tukanoan peoples of the Vaupés basin (Chernela 1983; Goldman 1979; C. Hugh-Jones 1979; Jackson 1983; Reichel-Dolmatoff 1971). Chernela's analysis (1983) of *po'oa* ceremonial exchanges among the Uanano of the Vaupés River is based on firsthand observation of prestations and counter-prestations of food-gifts. The Uanano tradition of po'oa is a reciprocal exchange of smoked fish or game meat between wife-exchanging affinal sibs. The general rule of ceremonial exchange in po'oa is that "Only foods of equal value may be exchanged" (Chernela 1983:129). The owner (*putoro*) of a po'oa ceremony is the male leader of the visiting, or donor, group, and the host group can choose between making an immediate reciprocal gift

of smoked meat to their guests or deferring payment to a future po'oa at their guests' village. What matters for the Uanano is that the food-gift of smoked meat must be repaid with foods of the same kind and that cooked meat must not be exchanged for raw vegetable or fruit products between affinal sibs.[4] This insistence on exchanging products of the same kind is consistent with the strong preference for sister exchange and other forms of marriage between closely related sibs among the Uanano and other Eastern Tukanoan peoples. The same principle of direct, reciprocal exchange is evident in food exchange as in marriage. The rule that "only foods of equal value may be exchanged" (Chernela 1983:129) is simply another way of stating the rule that "only a woman given compensates for a woman received" (Jackson 1983:126).

Until the recent past, pudáli ceremonial cycles of the Wakuénai served the same social purposes of structuring redistributions of surplus foods in ways that reinforced, or perhaps created, ties of balanced reciprocity between mutually interdependent, equally ranked affinal sibs as po'oa exchange ceremonies among the Uanano. However, pudáli ceremonial cycles not only allowed but required that repayment of the initial offering of smoked meat be made in raw vegetable products. Although primarily a reflection of the contrast between bride service and sister exchange as ideal marriage practices the contrast between pudáli and po'oa also touches upon differences in attitudes between affines and in the status of women among the Wakuénai and the Uanano. As mentioned earlier, the father-in-law figure plays a prominent role in Wakuénai narratives about the space-time of mythical Beginnings, and until the recent decline of bride service, Wakuénai fathers-in-law had the authority to veto their daughters' marriages. This power of wife-giving groups to control the process of bride service was the principal means of ensuring relations of balanced reciprocity and equality between distantly related affinal sibs. For the Uanano and other Eastern Tukanoan peoples, the practice of sister exchange, or other forms of marriage resulting in relatively stable alliances between pairs of closely related affinal sibs, obviates the need to give fathers control over their daughters' marriages. In cases of marriage between distant relatives, the Eastern Tukanoans practice ritual abduction of brides, a form of negative reciprocity between affinal sibs (Goldman 1979; Jackson 1983; Reichel-Dolmatoff 1971). In other words, the Eastern Tukanoan peoples have polarized the category of affinal relations into two groups: (1) affinal sibs who are close relatives and with whom balanced reciprocity is practiced and (2) other, more distant or nonrelated affinal

[4]Such exchanges are considered asymmetric and can occur within phratries or between the Uanao and Máku hunter-gatherers of the interfluvial forests but not between affinal sibs of different phratries or language groups.

sibs with whom negative reciprocity is the expected norm. In contrast to this polarization, the Wakuénai lump together all classes of affines into a single category of "other people" (*apána naíki*), and they imbue this category with a multitude of ambivalent and contradictory meanings.

Another important contrast between ceremonial exchanges of the Wakuénai and those of the Eastern Tukanoan peoples has to do with the relative values placed upon the products of female labor and, more generally, on the social status of women. In their descriptions of pudáli ceremonial exchanges in Wakuénai were consistent in asserting that the female-owned gift of processed manioc pulp was equal in value to the male-owned gift of smoked fish and game meat. In the same manner, the female owners of pudáli (*púdalímnaru*) were depicted as persons of equal status with their male counterparts (*púdalímnali*). These verbal descriptions were also consistent with my observations of musical dances of pudáli at drinking parties, where women were not in the least bit afraid to criticize any flaws in the men's performances on flutes and trumpets. Nor was there any evidence that women's gardening activities were regarded as inferior to the male activities of fishing and hunting. In conclusion, the relative value attributed to women's horticultural products and to the status of women is somewhat higher among the Wakuénai than among their Eastern Tukanoan neighbors.

Pudáli Ceremonial Exchanges

Exchange as Symbolic Process

The ethnographic literature on ceremonial exchanges between affinal sibs in the Northwest Amazon region includes only a few short references to the symbolic processes of exchange. Jackson has noted (1983:202) that Bará ceremonial gatherings are like pieces of music in which every activity builds up to a climax. Also, Bará ceremonial exchanges outline a process of interaction between affinal sibs, beginning with performances that clearly demarcate host and guest groups and gradually allowing the two groups to intermingle, ". . . expressing symbolically how settlements, particularly affinal ones, interact" (Jackson 1983:203). These two observations on Bará ceremonial exchanges as a process of symbolic, musical interaction among affinal sibs are equally valid for the Wakuénai tradition of pudáli ceremonial exchanges. Each pudáli ceremony, whether male- or female-owned, began by establishing a clear boundary between visitor/donors, who performed musical dances outside in large ensembles around the food-gift, and host-recipients, who watched the performances from a distance. After the food-gift had been formally offered, accepted, and stored inside the hosts' house, guests and hosts began to interact more directly through singing and drinking together through the night. The com-

ing together of the two groups culminated in a day of feasting, dancing, and playing music together after the redistribution of the food-gift among host and guest families alike. Thus, much like the Bará ceremonial exchanges between affinal groups, pudáli ceremonies outlined a musical, symbolic process of first establishing, then transforming, and finally transcending the social boundary between host and guest groups.

Another, more specific parallel between ceremonial exchanges of the Wakuénai and those of the Eastern Tukanoan peoples lies in the importance of sexual symbolism in musical performances. In describing social gatherings among the Desana, Reichel-Dolmatoff noted that the dances all had a marked erotic component ". . . and above all they represent a ritual action that fosters fertility among animals as well as among the dancers" (1971:163). On the surface, Desana dances and songs refer to and imitate the behavior of animals, but implicitly ". . . all references to the river, the traps, and the catch are, in reality, allusions to sexual intercourse" (Reichel-Dolmatoff 1971:164). This ambiguity of meaning, or dual referencing of ceremonial music and dance to animal behavior and sexual intercourse, is a basic symbolic principle in all stages of pudáli ceremonies of the Wakuénai. At the most general level, all performances of dance-music in pudáli presuppose a connection between animal behavior and sexual intercourse, since the verb *-irrápaka* ("to dance") refers to both the musical dances of pudáli and the mating behavior of *Leporinus* and other fish species. More specifically, the dance music of pudáli symbolically links together animal behavior and sexual intercourse through collective representations focused on the reproductive behavior of various animal species.

The symbolic process of gradually breaking down the boundary between host and guest, or kin and affine, in pudáli was embedded in a musical and choreographic process of deconstructing the cultural separateness of humans from animals and of male from female humans. This process of deconstruction unfolded in three stages, paralleling the gradual symbolic transcendence of the kin versus affine boundary. In the first stage, the guests' performances around the food-gift imitated the reproductive behavior of *Leporinus* fish species through musical sounds, the naming of dances, and sexual meanings attributed to the material construction of flutes and trumpets. In the second stage, the guest men "asked" their hosts for manioc beer by imitating the eating and reproductive behavior of coconut palm weevils (*déetu*). In the final stage of feasting and dancing after the redistribution of the food-gift, hosts and guests joined together to perform improvisatory musical dances that directly represented the reproductive behaviors of fish and other animal species. In the first stage, maleness and femaleness were represented as complementary, reciprocal, and interlocking categories of social being. This imagery of gender reciprocity was

transformed in the late-night performances into expressions of ambisexuality and nonsexuality. Finally, in the third stage of pudáli, maleness and femaleness were transcended in performances which express the concept of presexuality, or the interchangeability, of male and female gender.

The description of ceremonial activities in the following three sections synthesizes information that was elicited from adult men and women who had personally participated in pudáli in the past, when it was still practiced as a ceremonial food-exchange between affinal sibs. In addition, the description includes detailed information on the organization of musical sounds, construction of musical instruments, and the spatial movements of dancers, all of which are based on firsthand participant observation in social occasions when people gathered to drink and dance together during my fieldwork in 1980–1981.

Male-Owned Pudáli Ceremonies

Pudáli ceremonial cycles celebrated the simultaneous climax of horticultural and fishing activities at the beginning of the long wet season. In opening, male-owned ceremonies, a local group visited a host group of actual or potential affines and formally offered them a gift of smoked fish or game meat. The *púdalímnali*, or male owner of pudáli, led his kin group and their wives into the hosts' village in a procession of flute-players, trumpet-players, singers, dancers, and food-bearers. Large ceremonial trumpets, named after a species of large, striped catfish (*kulírri*, Wáku; *Brachyplatystoma* sp.), created a deep, rumbling bass-ostinato that was said to represent the sound of a river full to the brim with spawning, migrating fish. Male trumpet-players and female dancers circled around the heap of smoked fish in dances named after the white, spotted, and red-tailed *Leporinus* fish (*táari, dúme,* and *dúpari*, respectively).[5] In front of the trumpet-players, a pair of *máwi* flute-players and their female dance partners led the counterclockwise procession, which varied slightly in each of the three *Leporinus* dances (see Figures 2, 3, and 4). The music of these opening dances of pudáli consists of a highly standardized máwi flute duet, which is the most commonly heard musical performance in the pudáli genre of *mádzeru* (see Figure 5).

Other musicians joined into the *Leporinus* dances to make the procession larger and more impressive. *Tsikóta* flute-players, déetu flute-players,

[5]The *Leporinus* species are referred to as *bocachico* in Spanish and *aracu* in Portuguese. In describing Desana social gatherings, Reichel-Dolmatoff (1971:164–165) mentions that the Desana also have ceremonial dances named after the *Leporinus* fish species. However, the Desana dances make use of explicit sexual symbolism, as male and female dancers approach and touch one another, then back off. These activities are very similar to the Wakuénai flute duet called *dzawírra* performed in the third stage of pudáli and discussed in great detail below.

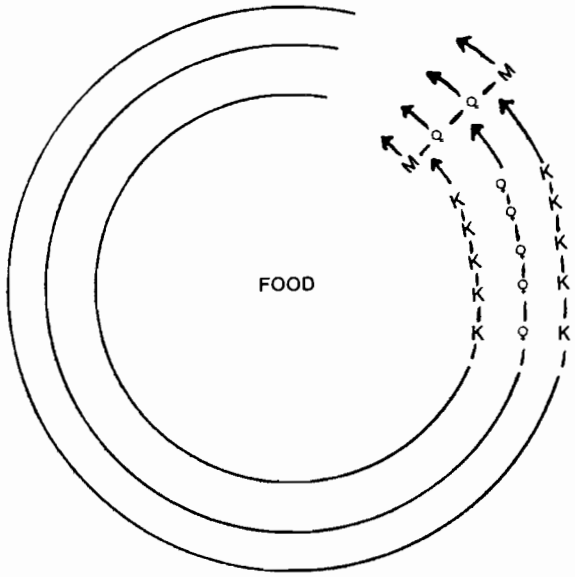


Figure 2. *Táari* (white *bocachico*) dance. Two *máwi* flute-players (M) and their female dance partners (♀) lead several rows of dancers, each one consisting of three *kúlirrína* trumpet-players (K) in the center and two partners (♀).

and *píti* whistle-players attached themselves to the tail end of the lines of *kúlirrína* trumpet-players and played as loudly as possible to be heard over the other, larger instruments. The resulting sound was not like a carefully orchestrated and conducted ensemble of wind instruments but a decentered, heterophonic collage of sounds ranging from the low, bass-ostinato of the kúlirrína trumpets to the ear-piercing soprano notes of the déetu flutes. This seemingly cacophonous roar of unrestrained, chaotically juxtaposed musical voices created the auditory point of entry for collectively evoking the space-time of mythical Beginnings.[6] The opening dances of pudáli produced on a nonverbal, musical level the social meaning of the event: a gathering of male and female voices without the imposition of hi-

[6]Wakuénai shamans' songs (*málirríkairi*) make use of a similar juxtaposition, or heterophony, of melodic voices which are rhythmically out of sync with one another. For shamans, these sounds are a musical bridge for crossing over into the space-time of the spirits of the dead (*lidánam*), which is connected to the space-time of mythic Beginnings via a number of narratives and beliefs. Most directly, the spirits of the dead in the dark netherworld, called *íyarudáti*, are said to perform the pudáli genre of mádzeru every day. Thus, in both mádzeru and málirríkairi, heterophony and rhythmical disarticulation of voices serve as musical means for mediating between different domains of space-time.

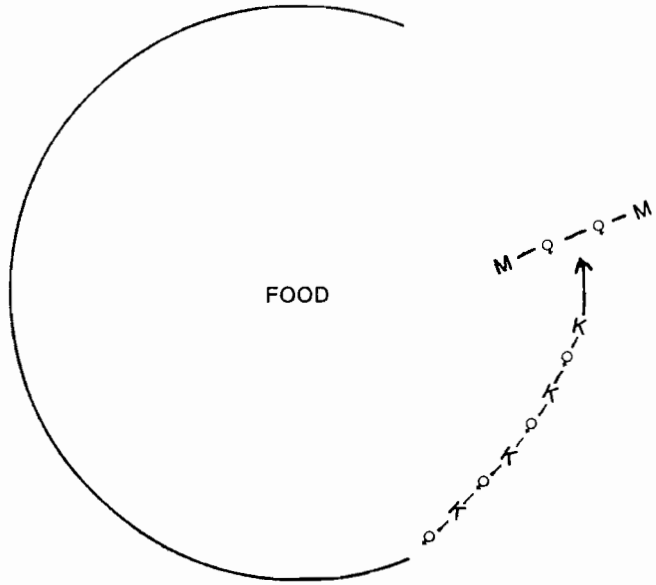


Figure 3. *Dúme* (spotted *bocachico*) dance. Two *máwi* flute-players (M) and their female dance partners (♀) lead a single-file line of *kúlirrína* trumpet-players (K) and female dance partners.

erarchical, centralized control. Higher and lower musical voices, female and male dancers, were fully and simultaneously given public expression.

The hosts listened to their guests' music and watched their dances from a *distance* until sunset. Then the púdalímnmali and *pantímnali* (the male house-owner, or host headman) made formal speeches of offering and accepting the gift of smoked fish and game meat, which was taken inside the hosts' house until the next morning. The formal speeches of offering and accepting the gift of food were the first step in transforming the collective boundary line between hosts and guests (or kin and affines). After the formal speech of accepting the gift of food from the sponsors of pudáli, the hosts' ceremonial leaders took the food inside their house and stored it on plátforms suspended between the horizontal cross beams. A large bonfire was lit on the dancing plaza outside, and the guests were invited to come inside the house to drink manioc beer and a variety of other mildly alcoholic beverages. Throughout this late-night, transitional period of pudáli, men and women sang personal drinking songs, called *pákamarántakan*, in which they asked one another for drinks. These personal songs all made use of the same descending melodic structure, but the song verses were created in a completely spontaneous manner, depending on the social sit-

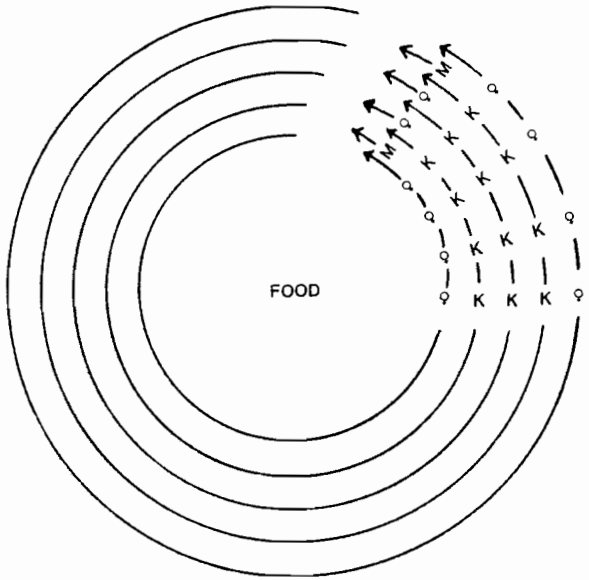


Figure 4. *Dúpari* (red-tailed *bocachio*) dance. Two *máwi* flute-players (M) and their female dance partners (♀) lead several rows of dancers, each one consisting of two *kúlirrína* trumpet-players (K) and a single dance partner (♀).

uation of the performers and audience. The emotional tone of pákamarántakan songs ranged from deepest sorrow over the death of a spouse to the most ribald humor aimed at friends or relatives present in the pudáli ceremony.

The pákamarántakan drinking songs provided a musical channel for individuals to communicate across the social boundary between hosts and guests, or kin and affines. The songs were also an occasion for making social commentaries which were generally kept at the level of private gossip rather than public performance. Every adult participant in pudáli knew how to perform pákamarántakan songs, making them the most generalized and unrestricted genre of vocal music in Wakuénai culture.

At the same time as men and women drank together and sang pákamarántakan inside the hosts' house, the guest men surrounded the outside perimeter of the house in performances on déetu flutes. The déetu flutes are named after the coconut palm weevil, a shiny black insect which feeds on sweet sap by sucking with its long proboscis. In performances on déetu flutes, the guest men imitated the natural feeding behavior of déetu insects by surrounding the hosts' house and playing their flutes up into the space between the thatched roof and the walls of the house. In this way, the
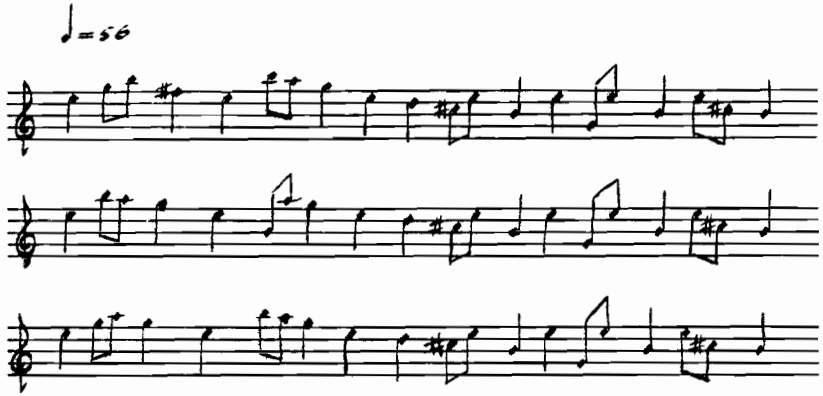


Figure 5. *Máwi* flute duet played in opening dances of *pudáli* and accompanied by other instrumental and vocal music.

déetu flute-players were said to "suck" fermented drinks out of their hosts, who came outside with large quantities of manioc beer. One by one, the flute-players lowered their raised instruments and drank until vomiting.

The symbolism of these déetu flute performances is discussed in greater detail in a later section. The performances marked the beginning of an important transition, a modulation in the socio-musicology of pudáli ceremonies, since for the first time a single type of instrument was played without the accompaniment of máwi flutes and other instruments. The collective activities of sucking and vomiting evoked the transformational powers of shamanistic curing, which revolves around the shamans' attempts to suck disease-causing agents out of their patients' bodies and vomit up these substances after linking them with external, supernatural causes of disease. The déetu flute performances of pudáli transposed the shamanistic techniques of sucking and vomiting, seen as expressions of the reversal of basic physiological processes, to a collective level and, in doing so, defined pudáli as a cultural event which was concerned with not only the social relations between kin and affines but also the symbolic relations between human beings living in this world (*hekwápiríko*) and the spirits of recently deceased persons in the dark netherworld (*íyarudáti*). By implicitly evoking the reversible space-time of shamanistic transformation, the déetu flute performances signaled the beginning of a collective transition from a secular, social process of food exchange to a mythical process of disintegrating the symbolic boundaries between humans and animals and between men and women.

In the very early morning (*déepitwawátsa*), just when the first gray light of dawn became visible in the eastern sky, the hosts came outside and watched the guests perform special dances around the bonfire. In male-

owned, opening ceremonies, the guests played kúlirrína trumpets around the fire without the accompaniment of máwi flutes. This dance was named after the resin (*maíni*) used to cover the woven resonators of kúlirrína trumpets, and the stated purpose of the dance was to cook the maíni resin. The sound of the kúlirrína trumpets played without máwi flutes served as a cadence which brought the late-night, transitional period of pudáli to a close. At the end of these dances, the guest men gave their kúlirrína trumpets to the hosts as reminders of their duty to hold a closing, female-owned ceremony several weeks later. The kúlirrína trumpets were the only musical instruments exchanged in this manner. The guests and hosts did not exchange máwi, tsikóta, or déetu flutes but keep them stored underwater for use in future ceremonies.

The third stage of pudáli began after the redistribution of food in equal portions to guest and host families alike in the early morning. The social boundary between host and guest, or kin and affine, was now totally dissolved in this daytime period of feasting and dancing. Individual men of the host group danced with individual women of the guest group and vice versa in máwi and tsikóta flute duets named after various species of fish, forest animals, and birds. Unlike the highly standardized máwi and tsikóta flute pieces performed in the first stage of pudáli, the flute duets of the third stage of pudáli allowed pairs of male flute-players and female dancers to display their talents as musicians and dancers through improvisation.

Female-Owned Pudáli Ceremonies

In general, female-owned pudáli ceremonies had the same three-part structure as the opening, male-owned ceremonies: (1) large, standardized ensembles of máwi flute-players and other instruments prior to the offering of a food-gift, (2) drinking songs, déetu flute-dances, and performances around a bonfire in the late-night, transitional period, and (3) improvisatory, individualized flute duets during the daytime period of feasting after the food-gift has been redistributed. The principal difference between female- and male-owned pudáli ceremonies is that a series of dance-songs, called *waanápani*, took the place of kúlirrína trumpet dances. The rhythmical, percussive sound of dance stomping tubes (*wáana*) which accompanies these song-dances is the source of the sub-genre name, waanápani ("stomping tube dances"). These songs all have a single melody, but there were significant variations in the song texts and dance formations during the course of ceremonial events (see Figure 6). In the opening song, the guests sang as a large group in unison as they circled around the food-gift of processed manioc pulp on the village plaza. Their voices were heard together with máwi flutes and other instruments.

I. Opening song of female-owned *pudáli*

Nínika númaka línaku dzákarekuwáya, máariye.
(I want us to come into the village like this, house-owner.)

Pímena piúmali línaku yákarekuwáya, máariye.
(You asked to hear us like this in the village.)

Dúpina piúmaka línaku dzákarekuwáya.
(Before you asked for this in this village.)

Nínika mápaima wánuka línaku, wánay-wá.
(We come like this without fear, playing *waana*.)

Nínika mápuni wánaku kéra-wírru.
(We come here lightly colored with red *kérawídzu*.)

II. Song for palm-fruits prior to food exchange

Nínika númaka línaku wétsirrú, línaku yákarekuwáya, máariye.
(I want *cucuritu* palm fruits like this here in the village.)

Nínika númaka kámare-rékani wétsirrú.
(I want *cucuritu* fruits with plenty of flesh.)

Nínika númaka yéemaka wétsirrúli.
(I want the standing *cucuritu* tree.)

III. *Dzúdzuápani* song performed before dawn

Nínika númaka línaku yúyuwína dzákarekuwáya.
(I want the small round fishnet here in this village.)

Nínika númaka túwiripíku, dzákarekuwáya.
(I want the yellow tail feathers of the *tuwiru* bird.)

Nínika númaka dáipukuliáwa, dzákarekuwáya.
(I want the wheel of *dzámakwápi* vine.)

Dáikenu liákani, dzákarekuwáya.
(Sleep is arriving here in this village.)

Níni námaru liákaninu yáwinúma.
(We open the jaguar's mouth.)

Nínika yánuwa máaripikúwa.
(I want to gather the whiter heron's tail feathers.)

Nínika númaka tárumi liákani yáwinúma.
(I want to close the jaguar's mouth.)

Figure 6. Text and translation of *wáana* songs from female-owned *pudáli* ceremonies.

In the late-night, transitional period of pudáli, the guests and hosts formed separate lines of dancers and performed *dzúdzuápani* ("wheel dance"), in which a miniature, circular fishnet (*dzúdzumáka*) was suspended over the bonfire between two poles carried by the lead singers of the hosts and guests. After the opening lines of the song, the lead singers and their female dance-partners split off from the two columns of response singers and began to circle the fire. They moved rapidly and changed their direction frequently, so that the fishnet in the middle often dipped down into the upper flames of the bonfire. The two pairs of singer-dancers had to whirl around at exactly the same moment to prevent letting too much slack into the lines holding the fishnet, which could fall into the fire and burn. During these maneuvers, the response singers remained stationary in two opposing lines (hosts and guests), marking time with their wáana stomping tubes. When the lead singers reached the verse "we open the jaguar's mouth" (*níni námaru liákaninu yáwinúma*) (see Figure 6), the two lines of response-singers danced backward, away from one another, until they were several steps apart. A few verses later, the lead singers called for the reverse of this movement: "I want to close the jaguar's mouth" (*nínika númaka tárumi liákani yáwinúma*). Then the two columns of response singers and female dancers moved back together until they had closed up the space that separated them.

The dzúdzuápani song-dances brought to an end the transitional, late-night period of female-owned pudáli ceremonies just as the playing of kúlirrína trumpets "to cook the maíni resin" signaled the end of the late-night period of male-owned pudáli ceremonies. After the dzúdzuápani performance, individual guest men and women of the two groups participated in the improvisatory máwi flute duets named after various fish, bird, and animal species.

Summary of the Exchange Process in Pudáli

Viewed as a whole, the three stages of pudáli outlined a process of establishing, transforming, and dissolving the social boundary between hosts and guests, or kin and affines. This three-stage process was expressed in parallel through a number of symbolic mediums. First, in terms of musical dancers, both male- and female-owned ceremonies began by asserting the boundary between groups of kin and affines by prohibiting members of the two groups to dance together while the food-offering was still displayed outside on the village plaza. The boundary between male and female dancers was transformed during the kúlirrína and dzúdzuápani dances of the late-night period by allowing groups of hosts and guests to dance, sing, and play music together. Finally, the individualized, improvisatory flute duets of the period of daytime feasting expressed a complete transcendence of the boundary between hosts and guests. Individual men of the host

group were allowed to dance with individual women of the guest group and vice versa.

A similar process was expressed through food symbolism. Like the individual male and female dancers who were massed into clearly defined social groups in the first stage of pudáli, the food offering was heaped up and displayed outside during the first part of the ceremony. After the food-gift had been accepted and taken inside by the hosts, the guest men and women were likewise invited to enter their hosts' house for drinking and singing. Finally, the food was redistributed in a manner that paralleled the breaking down of clearly defined host and guest groups in the individualized performances of the third stage of pudáli.

In terms of musical instrumentation, pudáli began as a series of dances in which an ensemble of different types of instruments was played together and later, in the late-night period, transformed into dances in which only one type of musical instrument (e.g., kúlirrína trumpets or wáana stomping tubes) is played. Musical sounds outlined a parallel process in which a standard, relatively fixed máwi flute piece with no changes in phrase length and only minor tonal variations was eventually replaced by highly improvisatory flute duets named after animal species.

The arrangement of male and female performers into circles was a constant feature of mádzeru performances at all stages of pudáli ceremonies, yet the central objects around which performers circulated changed in the course of the ceremony. In the opening song-dances and instrumental ensembles, performers circled in large groups around the food-gift. In the late-night, transitional stage, the performances began by focusing upon the hosts' house, including the singers and drinkers inside, in déetu flute performances. Later, shortly before dawn, the performances shifted outside to a large bonfire just prior to the redistribution of food. In the third stage of pudáli, pairs of male and female dancers became the central points around which other performers circulated. The three stages of pudáli are illustrated in Figure 7 in terms of the shifting focuses of musical performances. The ceremonial transformation embodied in the musical symbolism of pudáli was more than a social mechanism for transcending the kin versus affine division of everyday social life: it was a symbolic, collective construction of the presexual, precultural space-time of mythic Beginnings.

Musical Evocations of Mythic Space-Time

Gender Reciprocity and Its Modulations, or The Catfish Cantata

The idea of the presexual is expressed in several dimensions of the symbolism of musical performance and dance in the pudáli genre of mádzeru. One of the clearest expressions of presexuality is the way in which the Wa-

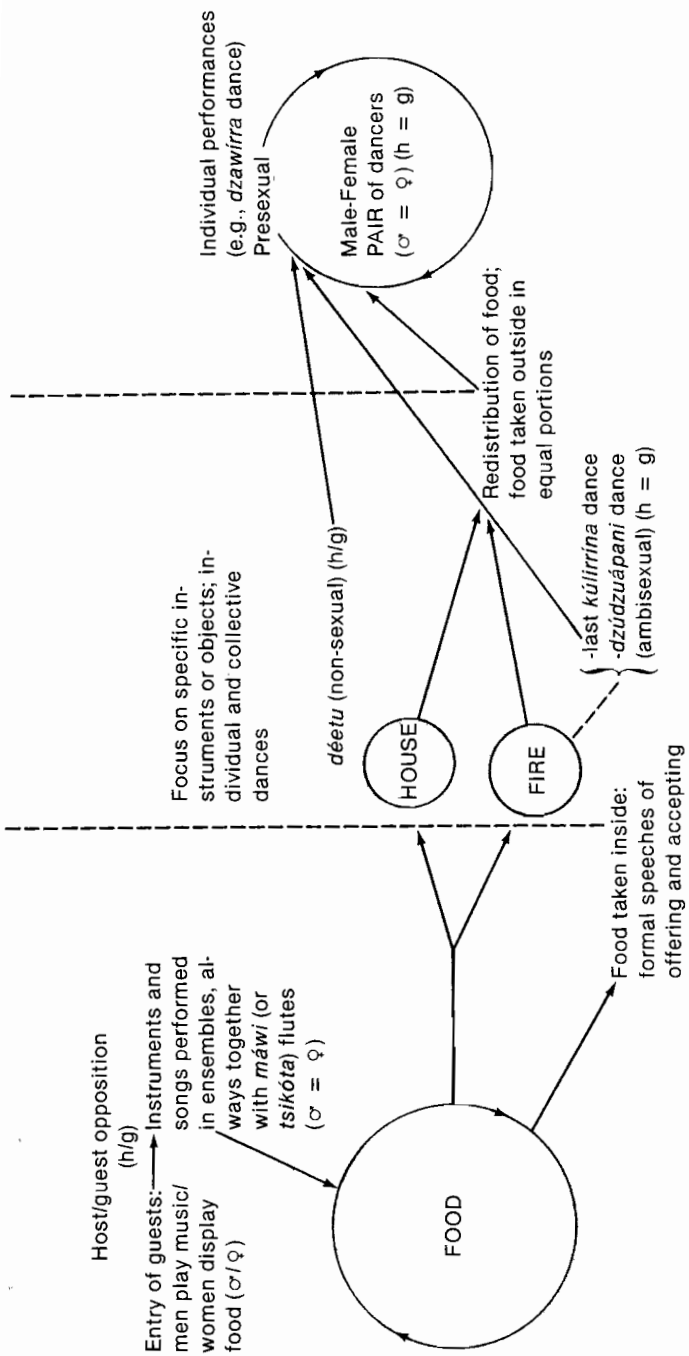


Figure 7. Analytical diagram of *pudáli* ceremonies showing convergence of several dimensions in *dzawírra* duet and idea of presexuality (h = g + ♂ = ♀).

kuénai attribute sexual meanings to musical instruments and performance. The long pairs of flutes called máwi, or *yapurutú* (lingua geral), are always made and played in "male" and "female" pairs. The shorter, "female" flute is equal to the height of a man's eyebrow when he is standing upright, while the longer, "male" flute is eight fingers' width longer. The máwi flutes lack finger holes, and each individual instrument is capable of producing only a set of overtones consisting of rather wide intervals. However, the shorter, female flutes produce a series of overtones one whole step higher than the male flutes so that the male and female flutes can produce melodies when played together in a hocket style. Máwi flute music consists of long chains of notes alternately played on male and female flutes. This interweaving of male and female notes is a symbolic expression of the idea of gender reciprocity, or balanced relations between male and female genders in Wakuénai social and economic life.

At the same time, máwi flute duets are played by pairs of male flute-players and female dancers. The formation of dancers in pudáli thus communicates the same idea of the interlocking, reciprocal relations of male and female genders.

The sexual symbolism of kúlirrína trumpets is more ambiguous than that of máwi flutes. The trumpets are named after a species of large catfish (*Brachyplatystoma* sp.), referred to in Spanish as *raiao*, or striped, because of the large black band that runs down the sides of the fish. The tubular, slightly bell-shaped resonators are made by weaving strips of *tirita* (*pwáapwa*, Wáku; *Ischnosiphon obliguus*) around a balsa wood frame. After weaving the tubular resonator, the men sew the lower ends of the resonators so that they flare out, resembling the tails of large catfish. When the men have prepared several of the woven resonators of identical shape and size, they prepare a large quantity of cooked resin (maíni, Wáku; combination of resins from *Monorobea montana* and *Mimusops bidentata*) and spread the hot, gummy substance over the woven frame to seal off air holes. A short tube of máwi (*Astrostudium schomburgkii*) is then inserted into the "head" of the resonator by lashing it into a circular rim of vine (*dzámakuápi*, or "two snakes," also used to make *kapéti* whips for striking male dancers in *kwépani*, the sacred dances of Kuwái). The circle of vine is made to fit snugly into the interior walls of the woven, resin-covered resonator. Several thick layers of palm leaves and maíni resin are then added to securely fasten the wheel of vine to the inside of the woven resonator. Then the loose ends of the tirita palm strips are gathered and tied tightly around the máwi-palm mouthpiece and a layer of maíni resin is applied to the outside of the trumpets' heads to make them completely airtight and ready for playing. Large black stripes are added by painting the entire resonators white with uncooked maíni resin over a masking of palm leaves. When completed, the kúlirrína is a long white in-

strument with a pair of long, shiny black stripes running down the length of each side. The men decorate them with red and white paint and feathers. On the white areas representing the belly of the catfish, two types of design are painted in red color made from *kérawídzu* (a cultivated plant, unidentified): (1) an emblem standing for the phratric name of the instruments' makers (nowadays, the phratric name is written out in capital letters, e.g., DZAWINAI) and (2) the pattern of lines sketched on manioc grater boards that serves as a guide for the insertion of the stone teeth. These two forms of design represent the phratry of the "owners," or givers, of an opening, male-owned pudáli ceremony, and they serve as symbols of the hosts' duty to return the offering of smoked fish in a later, female-owned pudáli ceremony in the form of processed manioc pulp. The trumpets are given to the hosts in the very early morning, just after the performance of maíni dances around a bonfire and immediately prior to the redistribution of the ceremonial food-offering.

Adult women of childbearing age are allowed to be present during the weaving of resonators for kúlirrína trumpets but are strictly forbidden to see the "closing up" of the resonators' upper ends after the men have covered them with a layer of cooked maíni resin. The men who were making the trumpets asked the women to leave the area, since "a woman would die in childbirth if she saw the closing of kúlirrína trumpets, for her unborn child would become stuck inside her womb." Although this statement was elicited from a male perspective, the women did not express even the slightest opposition to the taboo on seeing the trumpets closed. Both men and women tend to view the kulírri catfish as a strong food fish which must be avoided by pregnant women, the parents of newborn infants, adolescents undergoing puberty initiations, and sick persons. One woman commented that her brother's infant daughter had purplish spots (birthmarks) on her body because the girl's mother had eaten kulírri catfish while pregnant.

Aside from the general association of kulírri and other large catfish species with supernatural power (*línupanáa*), the men's statements about the potential dangers of kúlirrína trumpets for women of childbearing age have a more explicit, sexual implication through the analogy between female wombs and the trumpets' woven resin-covered resonators. If the resonators are like wombs, then the exclusively male activity of inserting palm-tube mouthpieces into the womb/resonators refers implicitly to the insertion of male penises in sexual intercourse. The construction as a whole thus expresses the idea of male and female union, an inextricable binding together of male and female genders into a single, ambiguous entity. As an expressive trope on the theme of male and female relations, the kúlirrína trumpets transform the idea of gender reciprocity embodied in máwi flute performances of the initial stage of pudáli into a concept of ambisexuality, or the synthesis of male and female elements into a single being.

Whereas the máwi flute performances express the idea of maleness and femaleness as interlocking sets, the kúlirrína trumpets carry this idea one step further to the idea of maleness and femaleness as interpenetrating relations within a single domain. In other words, the metaphor of "long flute is to short flute as male is to female" becomes transformed through metonymy into the part-to-whole relation of "male and female form part of the same trumpet."

In the transitional, late-night period of pudáli, máwi flutes are put away, and performances focus on imagery of the nonsexual and ambisexual as symbolic transformations leading from the gender reciprocity of the opening dances to the idea of the presexual. The nonsexual is enacted through performances on déetu flutes in which guest men ask their hosts for drinks by surrounding the house and playing their raised flutes up into the eaves, "sucking" out fermented drinks. These instruments are made from the same materials as máwi flutes but are smaller (1.15 meters) and are not made in male and female, or longer and shorter, pairs. Since déetu flutes are all the same length and "sex," they cannot produce melodic patterns through hocket style interweaving of male and female notes but only a single harmonic overtone series of several identically tuned instruments. Whereas prior to offering the food to their hosts, the guest men play déetu flutes as part of a large ensemble, including máwi flutes and kúlirrína trumpets, the men play déetu flutes without any other instruments during the late-night period. This change in musical instrumentation is part of the general ceremonial process of breaking down the boundaries between clearly defined groups of people, food, and objects in three stages.

The déetu flute performances embody the shift from gender reciprocity to gender neutrality, or nonsexuality, insofar as the male flute-players are not accompanied by female dancers. Thus, not only do the déetu flutes lack "female," or shorter, partners for making melodies but also the déetu flute-players lack female dance partners.

As mentioned above, the déetu flute performances of the late-night period of pudáli also evoke images of transformational shamanistic power through the activities of sucking and vomiting. When we follow this metaphorical relation between shamanistic curing and ceremonial flute performances to its implicit conclusion, it leads to an interpretation of the ceremonial house, filled with drinking, singing men and women, as a sort of collective body which must be collectively shamanized (i.e., sucked) by the guest men. This interpretation receives explicit verbal recognition in oral narratives about the mythical origins of pudáli ceremonies and the general belief that the spirits of recently deceased persons in *íyarudáti* spend the majority of their time drinking and performing the pudáli genre of mádzeru dance-music. These metaphorical comparisons between mádzeru and shamanistic performances are important for understanding the place of the pudáli genre of mádzeru within the overall musical culture of

the Wakuénai (see Hill 1983). In a general sense, the importance of evoking shamanistic power on a collective scale in the late-night period of pudáli is that it focalized the reversible space-time of recently deceased persons (*lidánam*) in the dark netherworld. This reversible, shamanistic space-time is transitional between human beings living in this world (*hekwápiríko*) and the powerful beings of myth. Thus, the déetu flute performances play a pivotal role in the ceremonial process of pudáli by marking the transition from a secular, social process of food exchange and intermarriage to a mythical process of breaking down the cultural separateness of humans and animals and of male and female humans.

The organization of musical sounds in déetu flute performances adds to the sense of reversible space-time embodied in the activities of sucking and vomiting. The music of déetu flutes does not move in any clear direction, since it lacks both melodic shape and phrasing. Unlike the máwi flute duets, which consist of melodic themes with clearly defined phrasing, the déetu flute music consists entirely of a simple, rhythmical alternation between higher notes of short duration and lower notes of longer duration (see Figure 8). The musical effect of these sustained, lower notes coming at very regular intervals is a feeling of circular, repetitive movement.

Like the kúlirrína trumpets, the déetu flutes refer multivocally to both human gender attributes and the reproductive behavior of nonhuman species. The kúlirrína trumpets do so through the sounds which they produce, said to represent the sound of a stream full of spawning *Leporinus* fish, and through the sexual meanings attributed to their material construction. The déetu flutes establish the same metaphorical comparison between human sexuality and the reproductive behavior of nonhuman species but in a very different manner. Because the flutes are all the same length, they refer to neither male nor female gender. At the same time, performances on déetu flutes in the late-night period of pudáli represent the natural eating, or sucking, behavior of déetu insects. These shiny black weevils are attracted to the smell of sap oozing from palm trees. As they feed on the sap, they deposit tiny larvae into the pith of the felled tree. After a few weeks, these larvae turn into large, oily white grubs (*mútsi*) which the Wakuénai harvest, roast in a fire, and savor as a delicacy. The metamorphosis of the white grubs into black, adult weevils is evoked in sacred dances of Kuwái (*kwépani*) (see Hill 1983), and in narratives the mútsi grubs are said to have magical powers of attraction over Kuwái, the primordial human being of myth. In pudáli, the imitation of the feeding, or sucking, behavior of adult déetu insects is a powerful expression of the idea of a nonsexual form of reproduction. Indeed, the life cycle of déetu weevils as a cyclical process of metamorphosis constitutes an image of spontaneous generation, or the ability to auto-reproduce. The déetu insect collapses the metaphorical relation between eating and reproducing into metonym, for it deposits its larvae, or reproduces itself, in the same place and at the same time as it feeds

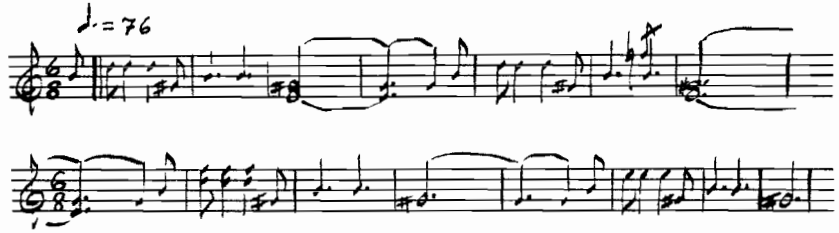


Figure 8. Transcription of *déetu* flutes played without accompaniment; melodic intervals found in *máwi* flute duets and songs are absent.

itself through sucking the sap of damaged or felled palm trees. The déetu performances, thus, are highly condensed symbolic activities which simultaneously frame a natural process of nonsexual, auto-reproduction and a mythical process of collectively constructing a reversible, shamanistic space-time.

While the déetu flute performances transform the theme of gender reciprocity into imagery of a natural reproductive process which is neither male nor female, the performance of pákamarántakan songs inside the hosts' house expresses the same idea only in opposite terms by constructing a totality which is both male and female. Pákamarántakan drinking songs directly embody the idea of ambisexuality insofar as men and women sing them back and forth in pairs. In place of the "male" and "female" flutes interweaving their notes to form a single melody, the pákamarántakan songs consist of musical dialogues in which male and female voices are blended into a single performance. These songs are the only context in pudáli in which women perform music and thus serve as a means for breaking down the symbolic categorization of male dancers as musicians versus female dancers as silent participants. In drinking songs, both men and women are singers, and neither are dancers. Together with the nonsexual imagery of déetu flute music performed outside the hosts' house, the ambisexuality of pákamarántakan song-dialogues inside the hosts' house expresses the transformation of male and female genders from interlocking, reciprocal categories into overlapping, interpenetrating sets.

This imagery of nonsexual and ambisexual performance is transformed in the special kúlirrína trumpet dances held at the end of the late-night period. The dances, called *wamaínina* after the maíni resin used to cover the instruments' woven resonators, make the instruments' construction into an object of symbolic thought and action. The purpose of these dances is to "cook the maíni" by playing the trumpets around a large bonfire. Fire and cooking are important symbols of transformation in Wakuénai sacred narratives and rituals (see Hill 1983, 1985*b*), and they are metaphorically applied here to the same sticky, resinous substance used to bind together "male" and "female" materials in making kúlirrína trum-

pets. "To cook the maíni" is thus a symbolic transformation of the idea of the ambisexual, or the overlapping of the categories of maleness and femaleness, into its ultimate expression: the idea of the presexual, or the total interchangeability of gender categories.

In female-owned pudáli ceremonies, the counterpart to kúlirrína trumpet-dances "to cook the maíni" is the dzúdzuápani singing and dancing. Beyond the analogy between the timing of dzúdzuápani and kúlirrína trumpet dances of the late-night period, there are important symbolic connections between the material construction of the miniature fishnet used in dzúdzuápani and that of kúlirrína trumpets. The small, wheel-shaped fishnets of dzúdzuápani are made from dzámakuápi, a species of vine that is also used to make a wheel that connects the mouthpieces of kúlirrína trumpets to their large, woven, and resin-covered resonators. Kúlirrína trumpets are generally not considered to be sacred instruments, and women are allowed to watch men making them, except for the moment when the wheel of dzámakuápi vine is inserted into the trumpets' resonators to connect the short tubes of máwi palm which serve as mouthpieces. The wheel of dzámakuápi which remains hidden inside the kúlirrína trumpets during male-owned ceremonies becomes the center of open, public display in the dzúdzuápani dances of female-owned ceremonies. In addition to having the same size and being made of the same material, the wheels used in dzúdzuápani dances are also analogous to the rims of vine placed inside kúlirrína trumpets insofar as both are representations of "small fish catching devices," the fishnet and the "mouth" of a large catfish. In both cases, the wheel or rim of vine also represents the inextricable union of male and female genders in a single object. And in both dzúdzuápani and the kúlirrína trumpet-dances "to cook the maíni," the association of a material symbol of ambisexuality with fire brings an end to the transitional, late-night period of pudáli and prepares the way for collective representations of the presexuality of mythic space-time.

Dancing the Presexual Space-Time of Myth, or the Fugue of the Five Sexes

On the day of feasting after the redistribution of the pudáli food-offering, guest men take host women as their dance partners (and vice versa) in máwi and tsikóta flute duets named after animal, fish, and bird species. Unlike the highly standardized flute duets of the opening stage of pudáli, the duets played during the day of feasting are improvisatory and make use of the musical principle of theme and variation. Each piece begins with a simple melodic theme made up of six notes played alternatively, in hocket style, on the longer, "male," and shorter, "female," flutes. The improvisatory, musical variations on themes are carried out in two ways:

(1) lengthening and shortening the length of phrases and (2) changing the pitches used within each phrase. Because of this flexibility in musical form, no two performances of a flute duet are exactly the same. Thus, the third stage of pudáli serves as a social context for allowing individual men to display their own unique talents as musician-dancers.

There is a great range of variation in the knowledge of these duets among adult men, and there are clear differences in creative inventiveness. The most innovative, knowledgeable máwi and tsikóta flute-players tend to be senior adult men who are also ritual specialists (*malírri* and málikai limínali). These individuals and their wives are virtual repositories of musical knowledge and creativity, and they are most likely to introduce a new musical theme into the style pool. Given the close association between ritual leadership and musical performance in Wakuénai culture, as well as the significance of specialized knowledge controlled by senior men and women, it is probable that elders have always played a similar role as organizers and innovators of máwi and tsikóta duets. At the same time, the role of elders-and-ritual specialists as repositories of musical knowledge has almost certainly been intensified in recent decades by the deculturative processes of missionization, formal education, and economic change. These processes have had a more direct impact on younger generations, resulting in a generation gap between elders who possess a wealth of cultural knowledge and young people whose knowledge is often vestigial at best.

Among the many improvisatory duets with animal names played in the final stage of pudáli, the one called *dzawírra*, after a species of small fish (*viejita*, Span.; *cicholasoma* species), was the most popular in Wakuénai villages along the lower Guainía River in Venezuela and Colombia at the time of my fieldwork in 1980–1981. The following description of dzawírra dances is based on three separate performances of the same duet in the Dzáwinai village where I carried out six months of fieldwork in 1981. I made a musical transcription and analysis of the dzawírra duet while living in the village, and this exercise gave me my first clear understanding of the improvisatory, theme and variation style of performance. After reaching this understanding, I experimented with the idea of theme and variation by learning to perform and dance the dzawírra duet with Wakuénai men and women. These practical experiences as a participant in máwi flute duets confirmed the results of my transcription and analysis of dzawírra.

The dzawírra duet begins with a pair of male flute-players dancing in a circle. The men support their instruments with the outside arms and embrace one another around the shoulders with the inside arms. After completing one full circle, two women join the pair of male flute-players. Suddenly, the pair of male and female dancers on the inside of the circle stands still, and the other couple continues on for a few more paces, turns

around to face the motionless couple, and then approaches them from the front-right side. They approach until the flute in front of them crosses underneath that of the couple who stands still. Then they back off and approach again. On the third approach, the flute-player who is standing still raises his instrument up high to allow the other couple to pass underneath. He continues to play the flute in this raised position while the other couple dances in small, counterclockwise circles around him and his partner. Immediately following this sequence, the roles are reversed and the couple that had been moving around the others in small circles stands still. The couple that had been standing still then goes through the series of approaching and backing-off motions before being allowed to pass several times under the raised flute of the other couple. After the role reversal has been completely acted out, the two couples rejoin and dance in a clockwise direction to the place where the dance had begun on one side of the dancing area. The end of the duet comes with the usual high-pitched, screeching sounds of the two flutes when overblown with maximum force.

According to the Wakuénai, the dzawírra duet portrays a female dzawírra fish protecting a nest of eggs against an enemy. They point out that the dzawírra fish stays with its nest until the eggs are ready to hatch, whereas most other fish species simply lay eggs and abandon them. The approaching and backing-off motions of dancers in the dzawírra duet are said to represent a process of asking the mother fish's permission to "dance" in a circle over her nest. Similarly, the raising of the máwi flute is said to be the mother fish's sign of giving her approval to the intruder to enter the nest. Although the indigenous explanation centers around the theme of protection against predators, it also evokes a sexual theme of male fish asking permission to "dance" in the female's nest. The spawning runs of fish are generally referred to with the word meaning "to dance" (-irrápaka), and the emphasis on fish nests and eggs in the dzawírra duet expresses a concern for natural processes of reproduction and their relevance as models for social behavior in the ceremonial context of pudáli.

The dzawírra duet uses the sexual symbolism of the male aggressor versus the female protector to construct the idea of a natural, presexual reproductive process in which gender is reversible and exchangeable. Keeping in mind that Wakuénai musical performers attribute male gender to the longer máwi flute and female gender to its shorter counterpart, the sexual meaning of the dzawírra duet is not simply that of a juxtaposition of male and female genders in which two male flute-players alternatively play the role of male aggressor. Instead, the dzawírra duet expresses a total blurring of male and female genders by acting out the transformations of male aggressor into *male* protector and of female protector into *female* aggressor. This same collapsing of male and female genders into presexual imagery is evident in the symbolism of dance, since both the aggressor and

protector roles are acted out by pairs of male *and* female dancers. One male-female couple acts out the male aggressor and protector roles, while the other male-female couple performs the reciprocal transformation of female protector into female aggressor. The reversible, exchangeable concept of gender which the dzawírra duets construct is so complete that it can be seen as an expression of transsexuality, or androgyny (Drummond 1981), a concept of spontaneous generation that preconfigures the dichotomy between male and female genders.

The dzawírra duet is also a powerful, metaphorical performance of the idea of the precultural, or a collapsing of culturally separate, human identities into a primordial oneness of natural and social orders. As with the idea of the presexual, the idea of the precultural does not arise suddenly in the opening stage of pudáli but through a series of collective representations that gradually transform the symbolic boundary between human society and nature. In the opening dances of pudáli, the human-to-animal connection is metaphorically expressed through the playing of kúlirrína trumpets to represent the sound or a river full of migrating, spawning *Leporinus* fish. The naming of trumpet-dances after species of *Leporinus* fish also helps to establish the metaphorical connection between humans and animals, or fish, and this naming practice is in turn part of the more general metaphor of "dancing = spawning" that pervades all stages of pudáli ceremonies. In addition, the construction of the kúlirrína trumpets out of male and female elements (e.g., mouthpiece and resonator, respectively) extends the metaphorical comparison between human sexual reproduction, gestation, and birth and the behavior of a natural species of large catfish (kulírri).

In the late-night, transitional period of pudáli, the metaphorical connectedness of humans and animals begins to take ascendancy of the cultural separateness of humans. In the déetu flute performances, male flute-players directly embody the natural, reproductive and feeding activities of déetu insects by "sucking" fermented drinks out of their hosts' house. In these performances, the connection between humans and animals is much more direct and iconic than the symbolic evocation of fish spawning behavior in kúlirrína trumpet dances, which depends upon mediation through naming of dances, the musical sound of the trumpets, and the material construction of the trumpets. In déetu flute performances, the "sucking" behavior of adult déetu insects is directly evoked through the guest mens' activity of surrounding the hosts' house and raising their flutes up into the rafters to "suck" out alcoholic beverages.

Finally, the dzawírra and other flute duets of the last stage of pudáli make use of the same direct, iconic embodiment of the natural reproductive behavior of nonhuman species, but they carry the process one step further. In the dzawírra duet, it is not just *male* flute-players who directly

evoke animal reproductive behavior but *pairs* of male flute-players and female dance partners who act out the protection of the nest of eggs and its penetration by an outside aggressor.

The total sequence of collective representations through which pudáli leads to the idea of a presexual, precultural space-time of mythic Beginnings is outlined in Figure 9. The presexual and the precultural are densely interwoven in the course of ceremonial performances, since it is the *reproductive* behavior of nonhuman (fish and insect) species which is focalized in each of the three stages of pudáli. To sum up, the presexual emerges in the transformation of gender reciprocity into representations of nonsexual and ambisexual reproductive modes, ending up with the imagery of the total interchangeability of gender in the dzawírra flute duets. The precultural begins with the metaphorical comparison, mediated by musical sounds and instruments, between fish spawning runs and human sexual reproduction in the kúlirrína trumpet-dances. This indirect, symbolic relation between humans and animals is transformed in the déetu flute performances into an iconic representation of insect behavior by male flute-players. Finally, the dzawírra duet gives direct, iconic representation of human-to-animal relations in the form of pairs of male flute-players and female dance partners.

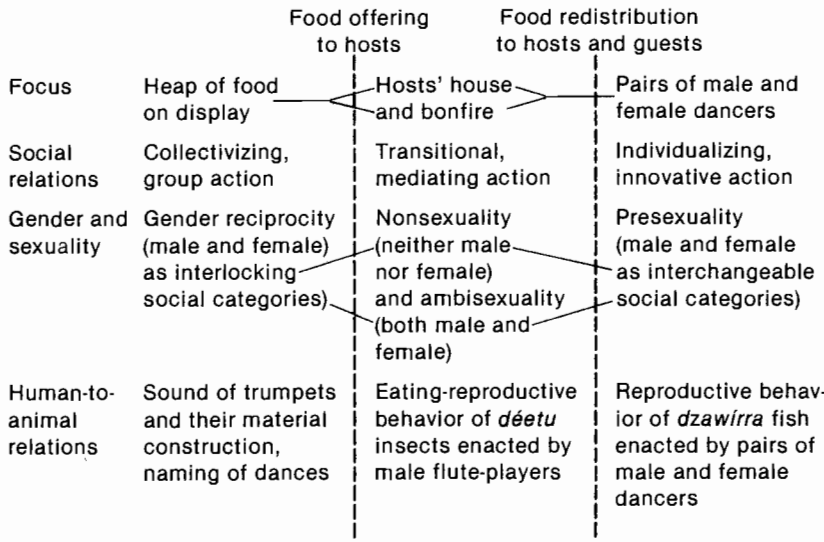


Figure 9. The three stages leading to the presexual, precultural space-time of shared mythic Beginnings in *pudáli* ceremonies.

Mawi Flutes and the Music of Dzawírra

In terms of musical performance, the collective activities of representing the presexual, precultural space-time of mythic Beginnings provide an interpretive framework within which individual men and women are free to display their talents as musicians and dancers. Máwi flute duets that have animal names, such as the dzawírra, make use of musical theme and variation that borders on "through composition." Performers take a simple theme and elaborate it into complex tonal and rhythmical structures with many subtle variations. To an untrained or unsympathetic ear, máwi flute duets might sound only repetitive and redundant, but careful scrutiny shows them to be a highly personalized musical medium that allows for the expression of individual musical abilities.

The Wakuénai term máwi refers to the type of small tree (*Astrostudium schomburgkii*) from which these flutes and all other aerophones of the pudáli genre of mádzeru (but not the kwépani genre of mádzeru) are constructed. Máwi palms grow in all forest-types of the region and are often harvested in quantities of twenty to thirty pieces in the process of clearing low vegetation for new manioc gardens. Bundles of máwi poles, each one about 2.5 meters long and tapering from 6-to-7 centimeters in diameter at the base to 4-to-5 centimeters at the top, are brought into the village. The straightness of the wooden poles and the ease with which they can be hollowed out make them ideal not only for musical instruments but also for blowguns. In addition, the hollowed out tubes are easy to split into long vertical slats used to make large fish traps, such as the ones erected at the mouths of streams during the spawning runs of *Leporinus* fish. The process of hollowing out the poles begins with an overnight soaking in the river which softens the inner pith of the wood, which is then easily removed with long, hard sticks of tirita palm (*pwáapwa*, Wáku). To smooth out the interior of the wooden cylinders, a long piece of *guambe* (*adápi*, Wáku), a vine covered with protruding knots, is threaded through the hollow tube of wood and pushed back and forth in a rapid, sawing motion. The hard knots on the guambe vine remove any remaining bits of pith inside the máwi tube. The flutes' maker cuts off any excess length and throws it away, making only one instrument from each máwi pole. The longer, male flutes range from 1.59 to 1.77 meters in length, according to the height of the eyebrows of the man who makes them when he is standing upright. The "female" máwi flutes are about 15 centimeters, or 8 fingers' width, shorter than the "male" flutes and range from 1.44 to 1.62 meters in length.

A rectangular, 8-by-1 centimeter hole is cut from the upper end of the flutes (the end into which the player blows) and is covered with two moistened leaves of *cucuritu* palm. A plug made of *perama*, a natural resin

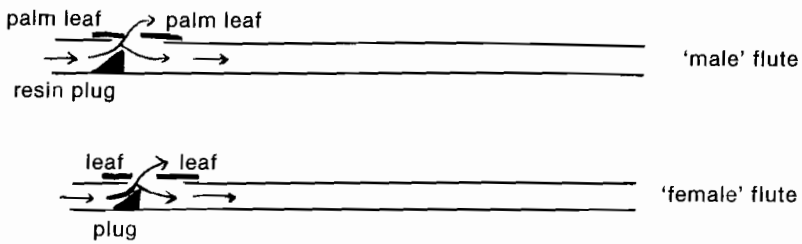


Figure 10. Cut-away sketch of *máwi*, or *yápurutú*, flutes showing basic features of construction.
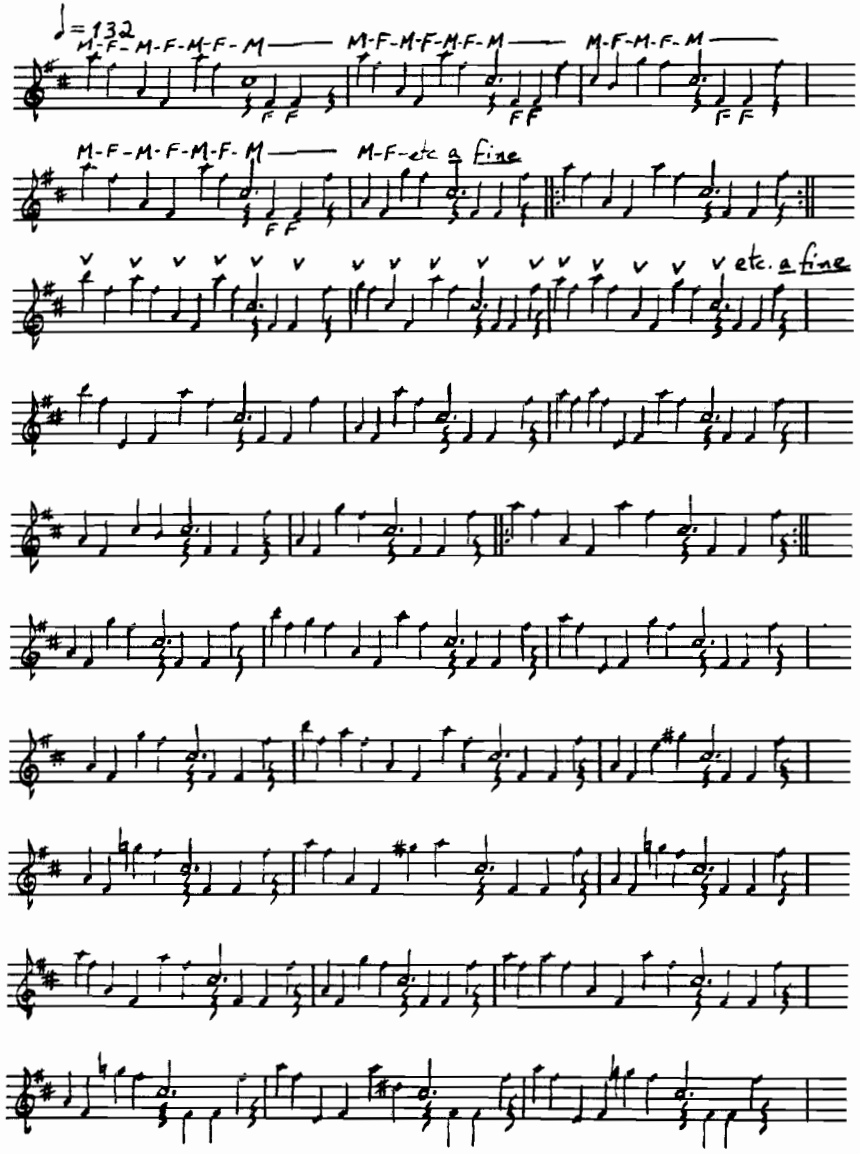
similar to maíni, is molded with a hot knife inside the top end of the instruments so that a condensed air column is channeled up and split against the lower of the two leaves to produce sounds (see Figure 10). The upper leaf serves mainly as a tuning device, since by narrowing the aperture between the two leaves, the pitch is raised. However, adjusting the space between the two palm leaves allows only a slight change of pitch, and when a pair of flutes is badly out of tune, the performers saw off minute slices of the lower end of the instrument that is sounding too flat. The actual pitches produced can vary among different pairs due to differences in the heights of men who make the flutes. What is most important is that the two instruments of each pair be tuned one whole step apart. In all pairs of máwi flutes, the "female" instrument is tuned one whole step higher than the "male" one. The instruments must be played in a hocket, or alternating, style in order to produce a melodic theme, since they have no finger holes for producing melodic intervals. Each máwi flute produces a series of overtones with larger intervals naturally occupying the lower register and smaller intervals of a minor third or less in the higher register. The "male" flute measuring 1.77 meters, for example, produces the series G (below middle C)-D-G-B-F-G-(A)-(C), while its female companion (1.62 meters long) produces an identical series of intervals only one whole step higher (i.e., A-E-A-C♯-E-G-A-(B)-(D)). The notes enclosed in parentheses at the upper end of each flute's tonal range can only be reached by overblowing the instrument. Each melody consists of a string of notes that are alternately produced on the male and female flutes.

Playing máwi flutes, especially while dancing, requires practice and skill. Since there are no finger holes, playing requires good control over the lips and breath. Lower notes are difficult to produce well because the lips must be relaxed inside the mouthpiece and the attack with air from the lungs has to be as slow as possible. This relaxation, or technical deceleration, has

to be done very quickly so as not to retard the tempo of the melody and dance. Many pieces required a constant changing from high notes that are produced with tense lips and a quick breath of air down to lower notes which require exactly the opposite technique. The quality of tone produced on máwi flutes varies a great deal from player to player. Beginners and young men who are less experienced have a hard time balancing the volume of lower and higher notes, often making loud, screeching high notes and weak, airy-sounding low notes. The best players are adult men who have developed a high degree of lip and breath control and can interweave notes into a melody with so much clarity and uniformity of volume that a listener cannot intuitively determine which player is playing which notes.

The dzawírra flute duet is one of the most demanding máwi flute pieces, since it requires a constant alternation on the part of each flute player between high and low notes at the same time as the performers act out the "asking" and "giving" of permission through dancing and physical gestures with their instruments. The tonal sequences of the two máwi flutes that were played in the performance of máwi transcribed in Figure 11 are A-E-A-C♯-E-G-A-(B) for the 1.59 meter "male" flute and B-F♯-B-D♯-F♯-A-B-(C) for the 1.44 meter "female" flute. The main theme, played right at the outset of the performance, is a 6-note melody plus the tail, a 4-beat sustained note (C♯) that comes at the end of each phrase in the piece. The tonal structure of this melodic theme is changed to produce ten other variants of the same 6-notes' duration in the course of the piece (see Figures 12 and 13). The main theme is also lengthened by two beats to make 8-note melodic phrases and shortened by two beats to make 4-note phrases. Both the lengthened, 8-note and shortened, 4-note phrases are altered to produce seven tonal variants each, bringing the total number of variants up to 27, all based on a single theme (*2a* in Figure 12).

The number of possible combinations and permutations for complete melodic passages is extremely high (28!), but in practice the amount of variation is limited by the greater number of times that the main theme is played (see numbers in parentheses after listing of each variant in Figure 12) and by playing two of the shortened, 4-note melodic phrases to form a sort of cadence. Figure 13 indicates the sequence of theme and variation in a complete performance of dzawírra and shows how the use of two consecutive 4-note phrases (shown as "C-C" in the top line of each row) divides the piece into sections that roughly parallel the major divisions of the dancing. No double cadence is played in the middle of the piece when the reversal of sex roles is being acted out through dancing. Instead, there is a rather symmetrical use of single cadences in alternation with single 6- or 8-note melodic phrases (e.g., C-1-C-1) before and after a central passage of three


♩=132
M-F-M-F-M-F-

1. Shortened, 4-note phrases

a. A-F-g-f	(15)	
b. A-F-a-f	(2)	
c. C-B-g-f	(1)	
d. A-F-C-B	(1)	
e. A-F-e-g#	(1)	
f. A-F-g-f	(1)	(differs slightly from 1a)
g. A-F-e-f	(1)	
h. E-F-g-f	(1)	

2. Main theme and variants, 6-note phrases

a. a-f-A-F-a-f	(19)
b. g-f-A-F-a-f	(3)
c. b-f-E-F-a-f	(1)
d. a-f-E-F-g-f	(2)
e. a-f-A-F-g#-a	(1)
f. a-f-E-F-a-D#	(1)
g. a-f-A-F-g-f	(2)
h. a-f-E-F-a-f	(2)
i. a-f-E-F-g-f	(1)
j. g-f-A-F-g-f	(1)
k. a-f-A-F-g-a	(1)

3. Lengthened, 8-note phrases

a. b-f-a-f-A-F-a-f	(2)
b. a-f-a-f-A-F-g-f	(2)
c. a-f-a-f-A-F-a-f	(3)
d. b-f-g-f-A-F-a-f	(1)
e. g-f-g-f-E-F-g-f	(1)
f. b-f-a-f-E-F-a-f	(1)
g. a-f-a-f-E-F-g-f	(1)
h. a-f-a-f-E-F-a-f	(1)

Figure 12. Musical analysis of *dzawírra* flute duet showing frequency of each phrase and its variants in parentheses. Small letters indicate notes in higher register, capital letters are lower notes. All C and F notes are sharp; other notes are natural unless indicated (#). The "tail," or 4-beat sustained note (C#) at the end of each phrase, is left out in this listing of themes and variants.

Dance Women join, "asking permission" to enter nest

Music
Intro-C -1 -C ------- 6 -------- C -1 -C -C("double cadence")
6- 6- 4- 6- 4- 6- 6- 8- 6- 8- 6- 4- 8- 4- 4-
2a-2a-1c-2a-1a-2a-2a-3a-2b-3b-2c-1b-3h-1d-1a-

Dance Permission given; dance in nest

Music
-2----C---2----C -1 -C -C-
6- 6- 4- 8- 6- 4- 8- 4- 4-
2a-2a-1a-3d-2d-1a-3a-1e-1a-

Dance Sex role reversal; no double cadence

Music
1 -C -1 -C -1 -C ----3---- C -1 -C -1 -C-
6- 4- 6- 4- 8- 4- 6- 6- 6- 4- 8- 4- 8- 4-
2e-1a-2a-1f-3e-1a-2f-2i-2g-1a-3e-1a-3b-1a-

Dance "Asking permission" to enter nest

Music
1--C----2---C---2---C---------------10----------------C--C-
6- 4- 6- 6- 4- 6- 6- 4- 8- 6- 6- 8- 6- 6- 6- 6- 6- 6- 4- 4-
2a-1a-2a-2b-1g-2a-2g-1a-3f-2j-2a-3c-2a-2a-2a-2a-2b-2a-1a-1b-

Dance Dance in "nest"; two pairs of dancers rejoin, leave dance ground

Music
-------5-------C -1 -C ----3-----C----E
8- 6- 6- 6- 6- 4- 6- 4- 6- 6- 6- 4----N
3g-2a-2a-2g-2a-1h-2a-1a-2g-2a-2k-1a---D

Figure 13. Alternative transcription of *dzawírra* flute duet in terms of phrase lengths (middle lines) and tonal variants (numbered and lettered according to Figure 12). The top line of each row uses the abbreviation "C" for 4-note phrases and shows the number of 6- and 8-note phrases in between each pair of 4-note phrases (e.g., C--2--C).

6-note melodic phrases. This passage (shown as ----3----/6-6-6/2f-2i-2g) marks a turning point in which the female protector begins to assume the role of female aggressor.

From Formality to Spontaneity

The pudáli genre of mádzeru performance orients Wakuénai society to the social principle of balanced reciprocity between local kin groups and their affines, who are perceived as potentially dangerous "others." The kúlirrína trumpet-dances of male-owned, opening pudáli cermonies focalize the brief period of superabundance of food resources during the spawning runs of *Leporinus* fish as a release mechanism that sets in motion human, social processes of food exchange and, ultimately, exchanges of male labor in return for female labor and fertility. Viewed as a whole, the collective representations of mythic space-time employed in the pudáli genre of mádzeru frame a complex, outwardly and inwardly facing process of deconstructing human cultural separateness vis-à-vis the external world of nonhuman species and the internal cultural distinction between maleness and femaleness in human society. By connecting the precultural and the presexual into a seamless whole, the pudáli genre of mádzeru naturalizes social processes of food exchange and intermarriage. What begins as metaphorical comparison between human and nonhuman species and between maleness and femaleness is transformed into metonymical inclusion of people and food, or reproducing and eating, into a single, ambiguous totality. The eaters become the eaten, the internal social world becomes the external natural world, and maleness becomes femaleness.

As a musical and choreographic process, the pudáli genre of mádzeru is a culturally prescribed ordering of the transformations leading from formality, rigidity, univocality, and relatively arbitrary symbolism to informality, fluidity, spontaneity, multivocality, and deeply motivated iconicity. These transformations are most evident in the musical performances of the late-night, transitional stage of pudáli. Pákamarántakan songs, for example, allow individual pairs of male and female singers to spontaneously create verbal representations of their social personae within the gathering of people at the ceremony while at the same time casting these verbal, social commentaries within a highly structured, standardized melodic form. In the déetu flute performances, a simple, stereotyped imitation of the feeding behavior of déetu insects performed in unison by the guest men multivocally evokes the idea of a nonsexual reproductive cycle of egg-laying and metamorphosis, the transformation of the food-to-sex metaphor into metonymy, and the transformational powers of shamanistic journeys to the place of the dead and back through sucking and vomiting. In short, mádzeru performances of the late-night, transitional period of pudáli embody the tension between rigidity and fluidity, or formality and spontaneity, which serve as the starting and ending points of the ceremony, respectively.[7]

Overall, the pudáli genre of mádzeru can be understood as a musico-choreographic process of *enabling* individuals to act spontaneously, to improvise, and to create new cultural forms within the constraints of certain key, organizing metaphors. The cumulative effect of the various subgenres of mádzeru performed in pudáli is to establish the primacy of the polymorphous, ambiguous space-time of mythic Beginnings.

Conclusions

In *The Raw and the Cooked*, Lévi-Strauss (1969) opened the way for an understanding of the complex interrelations between music and myth in lowland South America. Lévi-Strauss's focus (1966) on the tropes of metaphor and metonymy has proven in subsequent years to be one of the most useful analytical instruments for ethnologists interested in the interpretation of complex cultural events and processes (Wagner 1972; Sapir and Crocker 1977; Crocker 1984; Hill in press). However, Lévi-Strauss himself never sought to apply his theoretical insights at the concrete level of narrative and musical *performance*. Even when dealing with such sensuous, concrete activities as modes of aesthetic perception and expression in "The Fugue of the Five Senses" (1969), the French master of structural analysis ultimately reduced all symbolic interrelations to an abstract, binary opposition between positive and negative modes.

In this study, I have tried to show the advantages of a more practical approach to interpreting the social uses of metaphor and other symbolic tropes as genres of activity that enable people to cope with difficult social situations (Sapir and Crocker 1977). Taken as a whole, the musical and choreographic performances of pudáli serve the Wakuénai as a symbolic strategy for coping with the ambivalently charged category of affinal relations, or "others," through collective constructions of the presexual, precultural space-time of shared mythical Beginnings. The symbolic processes in pudáli are better understood as attempts to mobilize the expressive tropes of metaphor, metonymy, and irony to control and change empirical

[7]Goldman (1979) has interpreted the Cubeo *oyné* ceremony as a synthesis of two principles, male formality and female spontaneity. In general, the Cubeo oyné moves from formality to spontaneity over a period of several days and nights. The Cubeo oyné also resembles Wakuénai pudáli ceremonies in the social process of breaking down, or disintegrating, the boundary lines between clearly defined patrilineal groups. These resemblances between Cubeo and Wakuénai ceremonies may reflect historical processes of trade, intermarriage, and even absorption of whole phratries between the two societies (Goldman 1979).

social realities rather than passive reenactments in which the tropes are used to represent a presupposed social reality.

Wakuénai musical performances, together with the accompanying choreographic activities of mádzeru, lead progressively away from merely verbal constructions of mythic space-time into bodily, preverbal, sensuous activities. Paradoxically, the processes of musically evoking mythic space-time in the pudáli genre of mádzeru actively create an arena for fluid, spontaneous, improvisatory social action *at the same time as* they relate this inchoate human sociality back to the key organizing metaphors of Wakuénai social reproduction: male and female productive labor, female fertility, balanced exchange, and control over local fishing and gardening resources.

The pudáli genre of mádzeru gives insight into what can be called a musical mode of social consciousness. Unlike mythical and historical modes of social consciousness (see Turner in press), which are embodied primarily (though not exclusively) in verbal, narrative activities, a musical mode of consciousness rests upon nonverbal, or preverbal, activities which cannot be reduced to the formal, arbitrary symbolic relations of everyday speech and common sense and which bring into play reflexivity, multivocality, and iconicity. It manifests itself primarily through sounds and movements which are capable of expressing sharply defined structural patterns and transformations and yet leave these structural processes open to a theoretically infinite variety of interpretations. A musical mode of social consciousness thus allows actors to create indeterminacy and flexibility in social situations at the same time as it constructs a highly organized, nonreferential, universe of shared meanings.

The processes of musically evoking the presexual, precultural space-time of mythic Beginnings in the pudáli genre of mádzeru illustrate this dual tendency of a musical mode of social consciousness to open the range of possible, alternative interpretations of empirical social processes, and hence to create indeterminacy, at the same time as it erects a patterned framework for experiencing, understanding, and evaluating the same social processes. Thus defined, musical consciousness is inherently ironic, or "metatropological" (White 1973:37), since it enables individuals to rethink, reformulate, reevaluate, and comment upon their ability to adequately represent social processes which defy meaningful understanding through language alone. The mythical space-time constructed in the pudáli genre of mádzeru is not a state of being which can be adequately characterized through the referential functions of language, although it can be alluded to in narratives and verbal interpretations of musico-choreographic activities. Instead, the presexual, precultural space-time of mythical Beginnings is a process of becoming, a singing, speaking, playing, and dancing into being of primordial formlessness and indeterminacy. As Ellen

Basso (1985) has noted in her eloquent treatment of Kalapalo narrative discourse and ritual performances, musical performance places individuals, and groups of individuals, into a privileged relationship to the powerful Beings of myth, which are "sung into being" rather than merely "sung to," or represented in a referential manner.

In short, the musical mode of social consciousness which manifests itself in the Wakuénai ceremonial genre of mádzeru acts as a medium for deconstructing the socially shared meanings of being human or nonhuman, male or female, kin or affine, in order to open up the possibility of redefining the meanings of these basic categories of social being in publicly critical circumstances. As a process of musical and choreographic deconstruction, an ongoing coupling and decoupling of signs, terms, and meanings, mádzeru provides the Wakuénai with a strategy for *becoming* human or nonhuman, male or female, kin or affine, in empirical, historical contexts of increasingly dehumanizing, defeminizing, emasculating, and deculturating social processes.

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